

Fox Sedge

Carex vulpinoidea

Brown Fox Sedge



QUALITIES

A clumping native sedge of wet meadows, ditches, and vegetated bioswales, growing 2 to 3 feet tall. Narrow bright-green blades arch outward from a tight basal clump. In June and July, distinctive bristly seedheads emerge — each one resembling a small foxtail or pipe-cleaner, which gives the species its name. The seedheads turn from green to golden brown as they ripen and persist into fall, providing structural interest after most prairie forbs have finished blooming.

CARE

Moist to wet soil; tolerates seasonal flooding and occasional summer drying once established. Full sun to part shade. Hardy to USDA Zone 3. Plant from plug stock at 9 to 12 inches spacing for fast canopy closure. As with all sedges, the close spacing matters because the purpose is to outcompete weeds and bind the soil with fibrous roots. No maintenance required; can be cut to 6 inches in late winter or burned on a controlled spring schedule.

HISTORY

The genus *Carex* contains over 2,000 species worldwide and is one of the largest plant genera; it includes some of the most ancient grass-like plants on Earth. Sedges were co-dominant species of the sedge meadows that once covered substantial acreage in poorly-drained Minnesota lowlands. The Ojibwe and Anishinaabe used several *Carex* species for woven mats and basketry. Most sedge meadow habitat in Minnesota has been drained and converted to agriculture; what remains is among the state's most endangered ecosystems.

REASON TO BE

Fox Sedge pairs with Tussock Sedge as the structural backbone of a vegetated bioswale — the species that physically holds soil against stormwater flow. The bristly seedheads feed sparrows and small finches through fall and winter. The species hosts the larvae of several skipper butterflies and Eyed Brown butterflies. In a residential bioswale conversion (rock to vegetated), Fox Sedge provides the visual texture and the structural function in equal measure.